

Subject: What the August 2026 Millage Means for MSU Extension in Oceana County

Dear MSU Extension stakeholders,

As we approach the August 4, 2026, election, I would like to share information about the **Renewal of Separate Tax Limitations** that will appear on the ballot and what it means for Michigan State University Extension (MSU Extension) programs and services in Oceana County.

The proposed millage would help restore county funding levels that have decreased over time and support a variety of county services, including MSU Extension. For a home with a taxable value of \$150,000, restoring the County's operating millage from 5.6708 mills to 5.75 mills is estimated to increase County property taxes by approximately \$12 during the first year or \$1.00/month.

How MSU Extension Serves Oceana County

Through the partnership between Oceana County and MSU Extension, we provide research-based programs that support youth, families, and local industries. In the past year, Extension programming in Oceana County has reached more than 6,300 residents through educational programs, outreach, and community engagement.

Here are just a [few examples of the impact](#) made possible through local support:

Developing Youth and Future Leaders

- In 2025, 250 youth participated in Oceana County 4-H clubs, developing leadership, communication, and life skills through hands-on learning experiences.
- The 4-H Shooting Sports club is an example of a focused interest area that Oceana Community youth have shown significant interest in.
- More than 1,500 youth from Oceana County participated in youth activities, including year-long clubs, special interest clubs, educational engagement opportunities on the MSU campus, and other experiences that broadened participants' exposure to Michigan and beyond.

Supporting Agriculture and Local Businesses

- At the West Michigan Research Center, MSU Extension researchers and educators work directly with growers to address challenges related to fruit and vegetable production, irrigation, pest management, and climate resiliency.
- Farm Business Management educators assisted farms representing, helping strengthen the long-term viability of local agriculture.
- The MSU Product Center provided business counseling and support to local entrepreneurs, helping foster economic growth and innovation in our community.



MSU EXTENSION

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Michigan State University
Extension programs and
materials are open to all
without regard to race, color,
national origin, gender, gender
identity, religion, age, height,
weight, disability, political
beliefs, sexual orientation,
marital status, family status or
veteran status.

Michigan State University,
U.S. Department of
Agriculture and counties
cooperating.

Strengthening Families and Communities

- MSU Extension partnered with local organizations to support nutrition education and healthy food access for older adults.
- Our Managing Farm Stress program delivered educational workshops and resources that support the mental health and well-being of Michigan farmers and agricultural families.
- MSU Extension provided Open Meetings Act training helping leaders understand Michigan's public-meeting requirements and apply best practices for open, accountable decision-making. This collaboration strengthened public trust and enhanced the capacity of local boards to serve their communities.

Why This Matters

County funding is an important component of how MSU Extension delivers local programming and maintains a presence within Oceana County. If approved, the millage will help sustain the educational services, expertise, and programs currently available to residents. If not approved, reductions to non-mandated services, including MSU Extension, could impact local programming and community support.

Our role

As MSU Extension staff, our role is to provide accurate, nonpartisan information so you can make informed decisions. We do not advocate for or against ballot proposals, but we want you to understand how these decisions may affect programs that serve our community.

If you have questions about MSU Extension or 4-H in Oceana County, please feel free to reach out to me at kellyj56@msu.edu, or 231-206-4570.

Thank you for your continued support of MSU Extension.

Warm regards,

James Kelly
District 5 Director
Michigan State University Extension